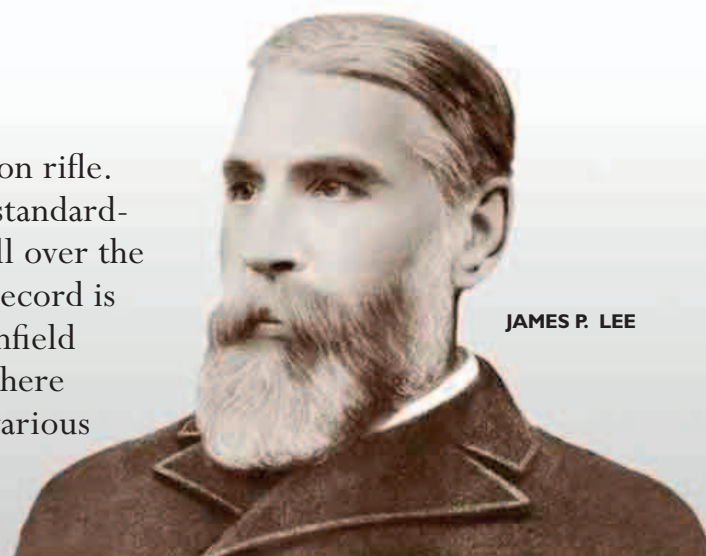


GREAT GUNSMITHS

LEE-ENFIELD

In 1895, the British Army adopted Lee-Enfield's bolt-action rifle. In various forms, this weapon was to remain the British Army's standard-issue rifle until 1957. It would see action in countless conflicts all over the world and is still used by police in some countries. This unique record is due largely to the brilliance of designer James P. Lee. The Lee-Enfield guns are named after him and the London borough of Enfield, where the original Lee-Enfield rifle was designed and where it and its various derivatives were produced at the Royal Small Arms Factory.



JAMES P. LEE

James P. Lee was a Scottish-born inventor and firearms designer who emigrated to Canada and worked in the US, where he made important advances in rifle and magazine design. His work came to the attention of the British Army in 1888, when they adopted the Lee-Metford rifle, which combined a bolt action designed by Lee

and a barrel created by William Ellis Metford. Users were impressed with the Lee-Metford, which had a "cock-on-closing" action that allowed very rapid firing. When the weapon was used with smokeless powder (see pp. 142–43), however, the rifling in the barrel wore rapidly. The search was soon on for a replacement.

RAPID FIRE

The problem with the Lee-Metford was that the smokeless propellant generated additional heat and pressure, which damaged the barrel's shallow, rounded rifling. The solution lay in a new type of rifling with a square shape, devised at the Royal Small Arms factory at Enfield. When barrels with

▼ BRITISH SOLDIERS

During World War I, hundreds of thousands of British infantrymen, on the Western front and elsewhere, carried Lee-Enfield rifles. Soldiers affectionately referred to their SMLEs as "smellies."

